

Inspection of South Tyneside local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 15 to 26 June 2026

Lead inspector: Gareth Dakin, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding

Services for children and families in South Tyneside have improved significantly since the previous inspection in 2023, when the local authority was judged to be inadequate overall. Children now receive good help and protection, those in care benefit from good services, and support for care leavers is a standout strength. This progress has been supported by a child-focused, stable, skilled and consistent workforce that shares senior leaders' commitment to a restorative and relational approach, placing children and families at the heart of service delivery.

Leaders have ensured a direct line of sight into practice and know their services well. They analyse performance information alongside feedback from children, care-experienced young people, families and the workforce, giving them an up-to-date and realistic understanding of the quality and impact of the services they provide. Areas identified for improvement at the last inspection have been purposefully and meaningfully addressed. Furthermore, leaders have a clear understanding of where further development is required and demonstrate a clear and unstinting ambition to continue to improve children's experiences in South Tyneside.

What needs to improve?¹

- The identification and support offered to young carers on a plan. (outcome 1, national framework)
- The exploration and reflection of cultural heritage and identity with children in care and care-experienced young people. (outcome 1, national framework)
- The purposefulness of practice and management oversight for children in need. (enabler 2, leaders drive conditions for effective practice)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and their families receive help that is proportionate to their identified needs, vulnerabilities and risks. A highly effective multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH) ensures timely information-sharing, strong management oversight and effective multi-agency working, resulting in prompt, well-informed decision-making for children. This is a significant improvement since the previous inspection.
2. Early help is purposeful and enables most children to access the right support. Decisions made at the 'front door' are timely and proportionate. Early help assessments and plans are thorough and are completed within timescales that are appropriate for children and their families. Assessments of children's needs are informed effectively by children's voices and the views of partner agencies, providing a balanced understanding of families' strengths and needs. As a result, children and their families receive help without delay.
3. Children receive a timely service from the MASH. When children are at risk of immediate or cumulative harm, workers respond quickly and effectively. Decisions are proportionate and ensure that children in need, or those at risk of harm, receive the right support.
4. The MASH's response to domestic abuse is timely and competent. Detailed analysis of family histories informs current decision-making. Risks to children are appropriately considered and assessed during screening. Managers maintain good oversight and provide clear direction to workers, resulting in a swift and focused response for children.
5. The MASH is effective in identifying children who may be at risk of exploitation. These children benefit from prompt and careful consideration of their risks and

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

needs. A coordinated response ensures that risks are well understood and that timely interventions are put in place to reduce risk for these vulnerable children.

6. The emergency duty team provides an efficient response to children outside normal office hours. There are clear and effective pathways for information-sharing between day services and the out-of-hours service. This enables workers to respond promptly to emerging concerns and take immediate action when necessary to ensure children's safety. The outcomes of strategy meetings are well recorded, with a clear rationale for next steps and actions that address risks to children.
7. Responses to child protection concerns are timely and thorough. Strategy meetings are convened promptly, with relevant multi-agency partners in attendance. Information is shared swiftly, enabling proportionate and well-informed decisions that assess risks and meet children's needs. Immediate safety planning frequently involves family networks, and plans are adapted as further information is gathered during the assessment process.
8. Children are seen, and their voices, experiences and the strengths in their family network appropriately inform decision-making and next steps. Child protection enquiries result in most children receiving effective help and protection.
9. Social workers carry out detailed and analytical assessments for most children, including pre-birth assessments, drawing effectively on family history and chronology to understand risks and identify children's needs. They reach well-reasoned conclusions that lead to timely and appropriate interventions for most families. Social workers engage family networks effectively throughout the assessment process, resulting in well-developed plans that help children be safer and that are understood and supported by families. Managers provide clear oversight, ensuring that recommendations are balanced, timely and purposeful and that risks to children clearly inform next steps.
10. Most child-in-need and child protection plans are appropriately focused on children's needs and risks. Social workers visit children regularly and work in a restorative and relational way to understand their experiences and respond to changing needs. For a few children in need, including those subject to supervision orders, planning lacks sufficient focus and does not clearly set out the purpose of the statutory intervention or the outcomes to be achieved. Management oversight of these children is not consistently effective in providing the necessary challenge to ensure that plans remain purposeful and progress in a meaningful way.
11. Children at risk of harm benefit from initial child protection conferences that are held within statutory timescales. These meetings are well attended by a strong network of multi-agency professionals who know families well. Children's views are carefully considered and inform planning. Planning is generally robust, with social workers maintaining a clear focus on reducing risk and improving children's experiences. This is leading to positive changes for many children. When risks

increase or plans are not proving effective, timely escalation ensures that children receive the level of intervention required to improve their safety.

12. The pre-proceedings process of the Public Law Outline (PLO) is used effectively when risks to children are not decreasing. Specialist assessments and meaningful engagement with families are prioritised, and creative packages of support often enable children to remain safely at home or within their family networks. Leaders maintain robust oversight of the risks experienced by children and the impact of PLO work. Where sufficient progress is not achieved, the local authority makes timely decisions to safeguard children. A very small number of children have been subject to child protection and PLO planning for an extended period. Strengthened management oversight is now ensuring that appropriate action is being taken for this small cohort of children.
13. The needs of disabled children are well understood by skilled and knowledgeable social workers. Children benefit from comprehensive assessments and purposeful planning that actively involves family networks. This helps to ensure that children can access a wide range of services and support, enabling them to remain at home when it is in their best interests.
14. Young carers are not consistently identified. While some benefit from effective support through the commissioned young carers service, others are overlooked because assessments and plans do not consistently recognise or record the impact of their caring responsibilities, particularly when parents have additional needs. Management oversight has not been sufficiently effective in identifying these children or ensuring that they receive the support they need.
15. Children at risk of exploitation benefit from a proactive and well-coordinated response. Early identification, effective multi-agency working and targeted interventions help to reduce risk and improve children's safety. Regular direct work and visits support children to disengage from risky situations. Partners share intelligence effectively, developing a comprehensive understanding of children's experiences and enabling targeted disruption activity that better safeguards children.
16. The response to children who go missing is effective and well coordinated. Return home interviews are offered promptly, and children take up the offer. This supports a better understanding of triggers and risks. Strong multi-agency collaboration between the police, children's social care and other professionals supports well-informed decision-making that reduces risk and improves children's safety.
17. Children aged 16 and 17 who present as homeless are informed of their rights and receive help to remain at home whenever possible. Creative support helps families to understand the causes of conflict and rebuild fractured relationships. Where this is not possible, children are accommodated without delay, but with a view to returning them home appropriately.

18. The local authority designated officer provides a prompt and robust response to allegations against adults working with children. Referrals are processed promptly, and responses are timely, proportionate and involve professional challenge, with a clear focus on safeguarding children. Clear and consistently applied thresholds, alongside well-attended allegation management meetings, support safe and well-reasoned decision-making that reduces risk to children.
19. Strong partnership working between teams supports an effective response for children who are electively home educated or missing education. Leaders maintain strong relationships with schools to ensure that vulnerable pupils with poor attendance are supported and appropriately challenged.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

20. Since the last inspection, leaders have responded effectively to all the identified areas for improvement, and practice for children in care has been strengthened as a result.
21. Children come into care when it is appropriate and necessary to safeguard their welfare. When children cannot remain safely with their parents, proactive efforts are made to explore all extended family options. The use of family group conferencing and family network meetings is effective in identifying suitable care arrangements for children. Positively, this is increasing the numbers of children who live with people who are known to them through a range of kinship care arrangements. This helps some children to maintain loving and caring relationships with those who are important and connected to them.
22. When children are unable to live safely within their family networks, leaders have a well-developed sufficiency strategy that helps to ensure that a range of suitable foster carers and children's homes are available for them. This is enabling them to live in homes that meet their needs and promote stability.
23. Children receive the care and support they need from a range of carers who advocate for them and champion their needs. Social workers get to know their children well and recognise their individuality and uniqueness. Social workers, alongside independent reviewing officers (IROs), want the best for children. This is reflected in the relational approach they take to develop and maintain meaningful connections with children.
24. Children in care benefit from effective, individualised care planning that focuses on measurable outcomes. Plans are reviewed and updated in response to changing needs. Social workers listen carefully to children's views and use them to inform plans and decision-making. As a result, children have plans that are child focused and aspirational, promoting progress and stability.

25. Children benefit from meaningful family time that promotes their wellbeing, strengthens relationships and supports their identity. Social workers carefully consider children's wishes and feelings alongside their individual needs to ensure that arrangements are safe, flexible and responsive to changing needs. Children are also supported to maintain important relationships, including with brothers and sisters who live separately, which helps to nurture those vitally important family connections.
26. Reviews of children's plans are timely, comprehensive and overseen by an effective independent reviewing service that provides robust support and challenge. Children are actively involved in their care planning, with views consistently sought and considered by their social workers and IROs. Children benefit from consistent oversight by IROs in looked-after reviews, and there is increasing evidence that IROs review children's progress between reviews. As a result, children make tangible progress towards meeting their individual developmental targets.
27. Children's cultures and identities are not given sufficient consideration in assessments of their needs, care plans or pathway plans. There is not enough professional curiosity or reflection about how children's culture, heritage and identity are explored and understood.
28. Leaders maintain oversight of children in their care to secure permanence, and, for most children, this is achieved in a timely way. Permanence options are considered, including adoption, with mature working arrangements with the regional adoption agency to find suitable homes for children, including older children. Permanence-tracking arrangements are generally effective, and many children achieve permanence through appropriate legal arrangements at the right time for them.
29. Most children who have been in care for some time live in stable homes. Careful consideration to long-term matching is given, whether that be long-term fostering, living in children's homes or in kinship arrangements. Leaders maintain effective oversight of permanence planning, ensuring that alternative options, such as special guardianship or reunification home to family, are actively considered when it is right for children.
30. Children who are placed out of area receive regular and purposeful contact and visits from their social workers. Social workers communicate and engage effectively with children's carers and ensure that they are not disadvantaged in any way from living outside the borough.
31. When homes for children are at risk of breaking down, social workers act swiftly to strengthen support and maintain stability. Effective multi-agency planning and tailored packages of support help many children to remain safely in their homes, reducing the need for unnecessary moves.

32. Children's health needs are quickly identified and are consistently reviewed. Children in care have access to a wide range of health and therapeutic services that positively support their physical and emotional wellbeing. Children's emotional needs are sensitively considered by social workers, and this helps to ensure that children receive the right support at the right time.
33. Risks that arise for children in care are identified promptly, and multi-agency work is carried out to mitigate them. Strategy meetings are held appropriately, and children in care are safeguarded through existing planning processes and networks.
34. Children in care who go missing or who are at risk of exploitation receive a proportionate and well-coordinated response to reduce risk. Most children are offered return home interviews. However, when children decline these interviews, follow-up actions and alternative attempts made to understand their experiences are not consistently evident in children's records. For a few children, this limits opportunities to gather information, reduce further risk and inform future interventions.
35. Disabled children in care experience stable homes that meet their individual needs. Effective multi-agency working with health partners and adult social care ensures that complex health and care needs are well considered and addressed.
36. Children in care who are unaccompanied and seeking asylum are supported effectively. Social workers take a sensitive, trauma-informed approach to their work to support children who have experienced loss and separation from their family.
37. Participation is a particular strength in South Tyneside. Children in care are encouraged to take part in a wide range of participation activities, and the 'MAGIC' group. These opportunities enable children to meet peers who have had similar experiences, and senior leaders. As a result, children are able to positively influence service development and have their voices heard.
38. Social workers carry out ongoing, interactive life-story work and capture children's key memories of important events. This supports children to increase their understanding of their journey into and throughout care and promotes their sense of identity. With the support of a dedicated life-story team, sensitively presented and timely life-story books are created. These unique chronicles of children's memories follow them wherever they are. Children can look back at these to develop their understanding of where they have come from, what they have achieved and why decisions were made for them.
39. The virtual school is ambitious for children in care. Leaders of the virtual school have had an important role in strengthening support for children in care, particularly in relation to personal education plans (PEPs). The PEPs capture children's voices and aspirations well; however, there is considerable variation in

how well written PEP targets are. As a result, a few PEPs are not consistently clear about how professionals support children's educational needs.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

40. Care-experienced young people benefit from stable and enduring relationships with their personal advisers. Personal advisers know their young people extremely well and are aspirational for, and committed to, improving the quality of their lives. High ambition is helping many care-experienced young people to make strong progress, build confidence and have positive experiences.
41. Most children approaching the point of leaving care are allocated a personal adviser at an early stage, supporting the development of positive relationships and a smoother transition into adulthood. Joint visits and planning between personal advisers and social workers help children to build trusting relationships during this crucial time. For a very small number of children with disabilities, transition arrangements are less effective, and some do not consistently develop meaningful relationships with their personal advisers before leaving care when they turn 18. However, the impact on these children is mitigated by the dedicated support they receive from adult social care services and their carers.
42. Care-experienced young people are highly valued and respected by leaders and the leaving care service. Their voices are influential in shaping the services they receive. They are actively involved in identifying what matters most to them. Their lived experiences directly inform service design and continuous improvement. Care-experienced young people reported feeling 'proud' of what they had achieved, particularly in respect to enhancements to the local offer. This work is well thought out, meaningful and is making a positive difference in how services are delivered to children in care and care-experienced young people.
43. Pathway plans are written in a manner that is accessible and highlights care-experienced young people's aspirations, wishes and concerns. They are purposeful and are underpinned by the voice of care-experienced young people. The plans are produced collaboratively and provide a meaningful reflection of each young person's strengths and individual circumstances. They authentically capture young people's individuality; their ambitions jump off the page.
44. Care-experienced young people benefit from a wide range of high-quality accommodation that meets their needs. Effective joint working with housing ensures that accommodation is identified promptly and matched well to individual circumstances. Many care-experienced young people can remain with their foster carers or are supported to return to live with family friends. Others move into supported accommodation or into their own homes. Practical and emotional support is readily available, meaning that care-experienced young people are very well supported to develop the confidence and skills needed to live independently.

45. The quality of relationships between care-experienced young people and their personal advisers is remarkable. Personal advisers consistently go above and beyond. They model what good parents and grandparents would do for their own children. They celebrate their achievements and stand alongside and advocate for them through their challenges. Personal advisers remain a trusted source of support. An embedded culture of pride and aspiration for care-experienced young people is supported by established and enduring relationships where they feel cared for and cared about. This gives them the confidence to seek help and pursue their ambitions with the knowledge that someone is there for them.
46. Personal advisers recognise the value and importance of staying connected with care-experienced young people, with a substantial number of older care leavers still in touch with the service. There is an inclusive expectation that care-experienced young people will be supported until they are 25. For those who feel that they no longer want a personal adviser post-21, these decisions are clearly reflected on their records. Importantly, they are then periodically contacted by the care-experienced ambassador and reminded of the support that remains available to them. This proactive encouragement by the service to stay in touch ensures that, where possible, care-experienced young people know what support is on offer and provides opportunities to reconnect.
47. Personal advisers prioritise the safety of care-experienced young people by providing flexible, purposeful and responsive support when help and protection are needed. Safety planning is used quickly in response to escalating concerns, helping to reduce risks for care-experienced young people and addressing their needs. Trusted relationships enable personal advisers to have open and honest conversations about exploitation, unhealthy relationships and other risks, helping young people to make safer, more-informed decisions.
48. The physical and emotional health needs of care-experienced young people are prioritised and responded to effectively. Effective partnership working between personal advisers, universal health services and the in-house therapeutic team ensures that care-experienced young people receive timely support to improve their emotional wellbeing, manage their health needs and build confidence to access services independently.
49. The local offer is comprehensive and extends to those aged 25. There is a palpable ambition that care-experienced young people have the same opportunities wherever they live. The offer is highly valued and well publicised. Many are benefiting from support such as a monthly schedule of engagement activities, council tax reductions, funded driving lessons and supported gym memberships.
50. The in-house wellbeing offer is a significant strength. Care-experienced young people benefit from timely, accessible support during periods of crisis and vulnerability. A skilled team provides a wide range of therapeutic interventions, alongside practical and enriching activities, such as stay-and-play sessions for

parents, sports sessions, cooking and an annual residential trip. These activities help to strengthen emotional wellbeing, build resilience and reduce isolation as young people begin to navigate adulthood.

51. Care leavers in custody benefit from effective support from their personal advisers throughout their time in custody. This helps them make progress and prepare for life in the community on their release.
52. Care-experienced young people who are parents are supported to attend the parents' groups with their children, and they take part in activities to build on their confidence and skills as parents. When risks to children arise, support from personal advisers is intensive and responsive, while helping parents to understand the reasons why professionals may be concerned.
53. Former unaccompanied asylum-seeking children who are now care-experienced young people develop positive and trusting relationships with their personal advisers. They live in suitable accommodation and receive coordinated support to pursue education, employment and training opportunities, alongside developing hobbies and interests. Their immediate cultural, religious and immigration needs are mostly well considered, which helps them build community connections and develop social networks. However, personal advisers are not consistently curious about how deeply they explore the cultural influences that shape young people's identities, experiences and who they are.
54. An opportunities broker, embedded in the service, is supporting care-experienced young people back into education, employment and training. Practical help is available with writing CVs, interview preparation and in developing the skills needed to achieve their potential and aspirations. Support pathways are in place to open opportunities for longer-term education and employment options, such as higher education, apprenticeships, and employment with local businesses. This helps care-experienced young people to access education, employment and training opportunities that are purposeful to them.
55. Leaders are committed to creating meaningful employment opportunities for care-experienced young people in the service. The established care-experienced personal adviser and care-experienced ambassador roles bring valuable lived experience and provide authentic challenge and insight. These opportunities enable care-experienced young people to develop their skills and really influence positive change for others.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

56. Senior leaders have worked diligently to improve, strengthen and refine practice across South Tyneside. From a low base, leaders have set the culture and conditions for practice to improve in a positive and sustainable way. Leaders have

a detailed understanding of their strengths and what more they need to do to continue to improve and develop services that meet the needs of children, care-experienced young people and their families.

57. Leaders have focused on developing a culture that is centred on a restorative and relational approach. This approach is embedded and provides a secure base for practice to be increasingly effective and impactful. Leaders, through their clear vision for services, have had a tangible and positive impact on practice. They have set a course for ongoing improvement in the help and support they offer to children, care-experienced young people and their families.
58. Political and corporate support is strong, and while there have been recent changes in the political leadership in South Tyneside, this support has been unwavering in its commitment to support children's services. The corporate centre, led by the chief executive, has a confident and assured grasp of the work that is needed to continue this progress, and children's services remain a priority area for the council leadership. The commitment and vision of the director of children's services have nurtured and built a highly effective and strong team to deliver on changes. By role modelling and implementing the restorative and relational practice model across the service, the strategic vision of 'one team' is being realised.
59. Well-established and mature strategic and operational multi-agency partnerships have strengthened since the last inspection. Safeguarding arrangements are clear, and there is an improved level of oversight and scrutiny. Relationships with police, health, education and wider partners are purposeful and focused.
60. Leaders recognise the challenges in providing sufficient high-quality placements for children. They have taken an entire system approach to sufficiency that starts at the very beginning of a child's journey and where safe to do so in preventing children from coming into care. Alongside this, leaders are addressing placement sufficiency through increased capacity to ensure that children who cannot live with their families have stable and caring homes.
61. Since the last inspection, leaders have focused on reducing the use of illegal unregistered children's homes for children. While rarely used, these arrangements are monitored by clear policies and procedures to aid the monitoring and safeguarding of these arrangements. At the point of this inspection, no children were living in unregistered children's homes.
62. Most children receive effective and helpful interventions from a skilled and knowledgeable workforce. Restorative and relational practice is a key priority. This is having a clear impact on the meaningful relationships staff have with many children and care-experienced young people and their families.
63. The self-evaluation provided by leaders is accurate, reflective and aligns with the findings of this inspection. It demonstrates a leadership team that has assured

confidence in many areas of practice and evidences the challenges that have been overcome since the last inspection.

64. A strong suite of data reporting and a clear quality assurance framework represent a significant improvement. These arrangements enable leaders to understand the quality of practice and children's lived experiences with greater confidence. Leaders use this insight effectively to shape priorities for continuous improvement.
65. Leaders draw on feedback from children, care-experienced young people, their families and partner agencies to refine services and ensure that developments are focused on achieving the most purposeful impact for children and care-experienced young people. Through a clear line of sight and purposeful collaboration with safeguarding partners, leaders are actively considering how the suite of national reforms is to be developed and implemented to inform ambitious future service design.
66. There has been considerable investment in the workforce, ensuring that more children benefit from consistent, skilled practitioners who use relationship-based practice. This targeted investment has stabilised teams and enabled practitioners to spend more time on direct work with children and care-experienced young people, although some unavoidable workforce pressures remain. This has resulted in a few children experiencing a change of social worker and some teams feeling under pressure with workloads. Leaders have demonstrated that they understand their workforce pressures and have taken action to address these and mitigate the impact on children.
67. The workforce in South Tyneside is committed and is an asset to the service, children, care-experienced young people and families. Staff consistently told inspectors that they feel part of something and regard South Tyneside as a great place to work. They value the support, advice and guidance they receive from managers, which makes them feel safe and well supported in their roles.
68. The quality of supervision and management oversight has improved significantly and is strengthening practice across the service. While a few discrete areas remain where oversight is not yet consistently effective, leaders have a clear understanding of these weaknesses and are taking appropriate action to address them.
69. The approach to co-production and engagement has a significant influence on how leaders shape services. The proactive use of the participation team enables leaders to hear and understand the views of children, care-experienced young people and their families and translate this feedback into their service planning. Leaders have also established a 'let's talk' group, providing a dedicated forum for parents and carers involved with services to reflect on their first-hand experiences and provide insight into how services could be improved. Leaders have already

used this feedback to inform service delivery and have ambitious plans to develop this further and increase its reach and impact.

70. Workers have access to regular and relevant training, and personal development is prioritised. This includes a good offer for newly qualified social workers, alongside opportunities for staff to develop their practice and skills and progress into specialist and leadership roles. The organisation's positive culture promotes staff retention and supports their development.

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